

Radiation Exposure and Worker Safety Analysis (2014-2024)

Summary

1. Overview

This report evaluates a decade of radiological data to assess the efficacy of current safety protocols and the long-term health risks to personnel. The analysis focuses on approximately 22,000 workers of which 11,000 workers had a measurable dose across the U.S. nuclear security enterprise. This analysis specifically examines the relationship between workforce growth and individual exposure levels and identifies higher exposure locations. The objective is to provide data driven confirmation of safety compliance and to identify high activity zones requiring sustained oversight. To ensure clarity in this analysis, two primary metrics are used:

Total Radiation Dose: The sum of all radiation exposure (Amount of ionizing radiation passing through or striking a person) across the entire workforce, representing the total radiological workload.

Average Individual Dose: The specific amount of exposure received by a single technician, measured mrem(millirem). For context, the average person receives approximately 300 mrem annually from natural background sources (soil, air, cosmic rays).

2. Key Findings

The longitudinal study of the 2014-2024 period yielded three critical insights:

The average individual exposure for a technician is **5G.12 mrem** per year. This is significantly less than **2%** of the federal occupational limit which is 5000 mrem. Effectively the workforce operates well within the safety zone, with individual risks comparable to routine medical diagnostic imaging.

Another critical observation between 2021-2024 is the monitored workflow grew from 1133 to 1167 individuals. Despite this increase in personnel and activity, the average individual dose remained stable. This indicates that the safety infrastructure is scalable, increasing productivity without increasing individual risk. Lastly radiation exposure is not uniform. Most of the total radiological workload is concentrated within 2 operations offices led by Savannah River and Albuquerque. These sites drive the national totals.

3. Risk Profile and Interpretation

In this analysis exposure is categorized into two types external and internal. To manage these risks each operational office is either '**Compliant**' or '**Monitor**' based on their specific profile. Compliant status is assigned to facilities where average doses are well below the 100 mrem action level and exposure is almost entirely external photon radiation. These sites, such as Idaho and Ohio, follow standard safety protocols.

Monitor status is assigned to facilities that require closer attention due to specialized risk factors rather than just high volume. For example, **Albuquerque** is flagged for its high neutron risk (62% of its exposure profile), while **Oak Ridge** is monitored for internal exposure risks (CED).

Exposure types range from external exposure (Photons and Neutrons) makes up 98% of the total and are managed through physical shielding. Internal exposure involving the inhalation or ingestion of particles accounts for only 2%, validating the strict respiratory and clean-room protocols.

4. Recommendations

Based on the 10-year trend analysis (2021-2024), the following recommendations are highlighted. Firstly, maintaining aggressive internal controls. Continuing full funding for respiratory and anti-contamination gear. The 2% internal exposure rate is a success metric that must be maintained to prevent long term health liabilities. Secondly implementing targeted shielding at the six sites. Direct upcoming infrastructure budgets towards enhanced physical shielding at the Savannah River and Albuquerque hubs to further drive down the 98% external exposure rate. Lastly adopting real time heat map monitoring by transitioning from annual reporting to dynamic dashboards, this allows management to identify if a specific facility type is trending towards a Red Zone status in real life allowing for immediate intervention.

5. Conclusion

The data shows that the Radiological safety program is performing very well and stable. While total radiation exposure appears high at 984,000, the average individual dose remains consistently below 100mrem with an average exposure of 59.12 mrem against a limit of 5,000 mrem, the risk of long-term health effects remains mathematically minimal. Exposure is concentrated in a few high activity sites and is primarily driven by Photon radiation. This indicates specific shielding improvements and site-specific interventions would result in greater safety for the workers. A complex radiological workload is being successfully managed while prioritizing the individual safety of the workers.